

Inspection of Blackpool local authority children's services

Inspection dates: 8 to 19 June 2026

Lead inspector: Margaret Burke, His Majesty's Inspector

Judgement	Grade
The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families	Outstanding
The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection	Good
The experiences and progress of children in care	Outstanding
The experiences and progress of care leavers	Outstanding

Since the last inspection, leaders have continued to deliver sustained improvements for children, young people and families in Blackpool. Children and their families now benefit from consistently high-quality, innovative services that respond to and meet their needs effectively.

Blackpool is among the most deprived areas in England, with a dense yet transient population, significant inequality, housing challenges, and poor health outcomes. Demand for services is higher than in most areas of a similar size, placing significant pressure on children's social care and partner agencies. The chief executive officer's (CEO) mantra is indicative of Blackpool's approach: 'Context is not an excuse but reinforces the need to deliver better outcomes'.

Leaders have remained resolutely focused on the community, children and families, positioning children's services as a core priority across the council and wider partnership. This highly ambitious work has been transformational, well coordinated and firmly rooted in safeguarding and inclusion, leading to significant improvements in the experiences and progress of children who need help and protection, children in care and care leavers.

Services are now working together more effectively, providing wraparound support to secure improved wellbeing, better educational outcomes, timelier permanence and

successful transitions into adulthood. Continued investment in early help, family hubs, adolescent services and targeted support is facilitating better engagement with and responses to children and their families.

What needs to improve?¹

- Planning and reviews for children and young people, so that when change is not progressing, and experiences are not improving within the desired time frame, this can be more consistently identified and addressed. (outcome 1, national framework)

The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection: good

1. Services for children who need help and protection have continued to be significantly strengthened. The co-location and well-established relationships between practitioners in the early help and statutory services, alongside other key safeguarding partners in the Request for Support hub – the multi-agency front door – have strengthened the quality of decision-making and response to children.
2. Practice in the Request for Support hub is robust, and responses to contacts and referrals adhere to thresholds and are mostly timely and well informed. The response includes proportionate direct engagement with families and effective arrangements that enable children to move seamlessly between services in response to their needs and circumstances. However, in a very small number of contacts, the risk rating left these children without a timely response to ensure that their presenting needs were fully addressed over the weekend.
3. Families are offered a wide range of early help interventions that lead to positive changes in their circumstances. They are well supported by workers who are knowledgeable about local resources and who diligently work to ensure continuity of support during assessments. This includes services delivered by the established family hubs, strategically located in the most deprived areas, to provide a comprehensive, inclusive offer. Additional staff have now been recruited and are being onboarded to reduce wait times, following a small number of families having to wait for targeted early help services.
4. The stable and experienced emergency duty team utilises its generic role effectively, bringing an understanding of adults' needs and services to whole-family working with children. Responses are proportionate and effective, with strong partnerships enabling effective out-of-hours responses. Day services provide appropriate follow-up.

¹ The areas for improvement have been cross-referenced with the outcomes, enablers or principles in the [Children's Social Care: National Framework](#). This statutory guidance sets out the purpose, principles for practice and expected outcomes of children's social care.

5. Child protection enquiries and investigations are timely and analytical, with a clear focus on risk, impact and next steps. Children are seen promptly, often on their own, and practitioners demonstrate a good understanding of children's lived experiences. Multi-agency working is supported by effective collaboration across police, health and education, and is now a clear strength. Management oversight supports triangulation of presenting needs, historical information, and risks, resulting in sound safeguarding decisions and proportionate planning.
6. Children's voices are well considered across all areas of work. Direct work is a key strength in practice and is used effectively to inform assessments and to shape plans that reflect the child's lived experience and wishes.
7. Assessments of children's needs, including pre-birth assessments, are generally strong, thorough, timely and sensitive, capturing children's lived experiences and incorporating history, partner contributions and views from the family network. With clear identification of risks such as substance misuse, domestic abuse and criminality, they are used effectively to inform decision-making, with the vast majority completed within the timescales of the child.
8. Combating neglect has been identified as a strategic priority. Investment in workforce development is deepening the understanding of this cumulative harm. Identification of neglect has improved in recent years, with the effective use of tools and coordinated multi-agency interventions. However, there is recognition that some children currently being supported have undergone prolonged interventions with limited impact.
9. The response to domestic abuse is embedded and a clear strength, characterised by well-coordinated, child-focused interventions, and supported through family networks and multi-agency working. Risk is well identified and contextualised, with purposeful planning that is regularly reviewed. There is a strong focus on perpetrator accountability and child-centred practice.
10. Child in need plans are generally well developed and informed by detailed assessments and safety plans. They are regularly reviewed and benefit from the inclusion of the family network and strong multi-agency engagement, good attendance, and effective information-sharing. Children are routinely included in this process, and their views are meaningfully captured. Similarly, child protection practice benefits from strong coordination and oversight, with planning that reflects a sound understanding of children's circumstances. Child protection chairs provide appropriate challenge and maintain a focus on outcomes. However, while assessments are strong and many children make tangible progress, child in need and core group meetings do not consistently challenge drift or test whether interventions are improving the child's circumstances. Plans are not always sufficiently outcome-focused. Reviews and management oversight, while evident, do not sufficiently consider impact or drive progress, limiting the ability to measure change.

11. Support for disabled children and their families has improved, underpinned by skilled relational practice, thorough assessments and sustained family network and multi-agency involvement. Planning is increasingly tailored and supported by specialist services, resulting in more coordinated and effective interventions. Although support remains effective, capacity pressures in the short-break provision have led to delays in annual reviews of assessments, limiting responsiveness to the changing needs of a small number of children.
12. Practice for children subject to pre-proceedings has improved considerably since the last focus visit. Decisions demonstrate secure threshold applications and effective risk analysis, with most work now carried out in a timely manner, supported by appropriate management oversight and legal advice. Documentation is clearer, with improved letters before proceedings. Meetings and interventions are timely, thereby significantly reducing drift and delay for children.
13. Care proceedings are informed by clear, analytical evidence, with social work statements providing a robust account of children's lived experiences and the local authority's plans. Family options are thoroughly explored during the pre-proceedings stage of the Public Law Outline. Both the Designated Family Judge and the Children and Family Court Advisory and Support Service have recognised Blackpool's increasing strengths in using proceedings effectively to safeguard children. A particularly noteworthy strength is Blackpool's focus on parents and newborns. This focus is making a significant difference to how mothers and children experience removal, supporting timelier, more effective outcomes for this particularly vulnerable cohort.
14. The authority's response to allegations involving people who work with children is supported by a clear referral pathway and effective multi-agency collaboration. The service benefits from a strong learning culture, robust systems and accurate recording, which support effective oversight and ensure continuity of information to safeguard children.
15. There are clear systems for identifying and escalating missing and exploitation risks, which help children remain safer in the community. Concerns are recognised and addressed through appropriate pathways, including by the specialist team Awaken. Safety and trigger plans are regularly reviewed and updated, with evidence of contextual thinking, and this is helping to increase safety. Regular review mechanisms, including exploitation meetings and a scrutiny panel, ensure strong oversight of plans and multi-agency ownership of risk.
16. Private fostering arrangements benefit from a strong strategic focus and consistent practice. Assessments are comprehensive, and safeguarding checks are routinely carried out. Management oversight is robust and reflective, supporting a strong quality assurance culture and positive outcomes for children.

17. The response to 16- and 17-year-olds presenting as homeless is effective, with a sound focus on helping children remain with their families where appropriate. Assessments are thorough and consider a range of options, and advocacy is consistently provided. Where children become looked after, arrangements are appropriate, and post-18 support contributes to stability.
18. Work with young carers supports early identification and timely intervention. Children's emotional needs are often recognised, but other aspects of their caring responsibilities are not clearly articulated in assessments and plans, to ensure that the support offered better reflects their needs.
19. Supporting children on the edge of care is embedded as an approach rather than a discrete service, with relational and strengths-based practice supporting children to remain safely with their families. Access to flexible services complements statutory intervention and helps avoid the need for care. Transitions are well supported, with a focus on maintaining positive family relationships. For a very small number of children in private family arrangements, decisions made placed restrictions on parental responsibility without having the legal authority to require this. This, however, is rectified before becoming detrimental to the children.
20. Arrangements for children missing education and those electively home educated are increasingly effective. There is strong oversight, a safeguarding-led approach and clear multi-agency collaboration. Systems are well embedded, with evidence of a positive impact on children's engagement and reintegration.

The experiences and progress of children in care: outstanding

21. For most children, decisions to place them in Blackpool's care are appropriate, timely and grounded in analytical assessments. When separation from parents is necessary, it is carefully planned. The focus on decision-making has improved planning quality, with a clear strengthening in the use of legal planning processes.
22. Children in care live in suitable homes, where they are integrated into the family's or the home's life, enabling a sense of belonging and stability. Decisions informed by professional analysis of family networks help children maintain continuity in significant relationships.
23. Permanence, in all its forms, is a strength in Blackpool. It is considered at the earliest opportunity, ensuring that children know where they will stay for the rest of their time in care, including the option to 'stay put'. Consideration is given to securing permanence through kinship carers, connected carers, and special guardianship order (SGO) arrangements. These assessments are robust and clearly focused on equipping carers to care for children. Carers who progress to SGO arrangements have detailed plans that include a clear statement of financial support, access to ongoing training, and other entitlements for carers and their

children, ensuring there is no detriment to carers who move from fostering to SGO. Children in these placements are well supported through SGO arrangements and ongoing social worker arrangements for as long as required.

24. Children in care plans are a credible strength. 'My Plans' are detailed, dynamic and regularly updated, informed by assessments, and provide a well-presented, comprehensive overview of the child. They are child friendly, trauma informed and written for the child. They include the child's voice, and children's wishes and feelings inform decisions. My Plan care planning meetings are additional meetings held regularly to ensure that children remain central to the development and review of their plans. Plans are routinely reviewed at well-attended, well-structured Supporting Our Children statutory reviews, chaired by the independent reviewing officer (IRO). Most children attend their formal reviews, and their voices are clearly recorded.
25. IROs' oversight is strong. Many IROs have enduring relationships with children, having worked with them for many years, and demonstrate an understanding of children's needs, wishes and individual challenges. Where escalation is used, it is purposeful and impactful, for example, in advancing delayed care planning.
26. Children, including disabled children, benefit from high-quality, relationship-based practice. Children are visited regularly, in line with need. Visits are meaningful, and the child's voice, wishes and feelings are clearly recorded. Social workers know their children well and provide a consistent source of support, often over many years. Skilled life-story and virtual memory box (VMB) work helps children understand their histories in a sensitive, developmentally appropriate way, strengthening their sense of identity, emotional security and resilience. Therapeutic and pastoral support is provided as appropriate for children with emotional health needs or who are experiencing anxiety.
27. The offer for separated migrant children and care leavers is strong, holistic and trauma informed. Plans for children and young people are detailed and well considered. The use of interpreters for children and young people ensures that they have full access to information and can be heard. Support is provided by knowledgeable and experienced personal advisers (PAs) through what can be a challenging and anxiety-provoking asylum claim journey. Social workers are aware of risks and respond appropriately, including through safety planning. Consideration of emotional and mental health needs has led to talking therapies and support for some children. Contact with the Red Cross and efforts to ensure that children and young people have access to family and others important to them are included in the child's plan, reducing some anxieties and trauma caused by being so far from home or by concerns about those left behind.
28. Decisions regarding the use of secure placements, when required, are managed effectively. Children in these placements are supported effectively by social workers, with regular scrutiny by senior managers to ensure that follow-on placements and wraparound support are identified. Children are helped to

develop insight into the risks involved, ensuring that they have the best opportunity to do well in the community without depriving them of the same level of liberty as their peers.

29. For the very small number of children living in unregistered placements, there is strong senior leadership oversight and child-centred decision-making, with a high level of support that is regularly reviewed and involves joint working with multi-agency partners. These children's needs and vulnerabilities are well understood. These placements are used in emergency circumstances and for only a limited period. They are supported by robust mitigation and clear exit planning. There is regular scrutiny of unregistered provision through the legal gateway panel and case review meetings. Young people in these placements have ongoing, detailed risk assessments, enhanced safeguarding arrangements and regular commissioning quality assurance checks.
30. Children in care who return to live with their parents benefit from structured, child-centred assessments and plans, supported by care planning meetings and regular reviews. Updated assessments inform future plans, including the discharge of care orders, helping to avoid drift and delay in securing permanence with their parents. While there is some variability in the level of detail recorded in children's records for compliance and safeguarding checks, this has been recognised and reviewed, with immediate action taken to ensure that this information is more readily accessible.
31. Rigorous senior management oversight of arrangements and searches for homes for children has been strengthened, improving timely permanence for children. Placement stability is supported by strong, positive relationships between children and their carers. Many arrangements reflect children's expressed wishes and feelings, align with their individual needs and are ratified by their IRO. A range of services is available, from practical and emotional support for the child and carer to more clinical and therapeutic interventions. When support cannot sustain placements, thoughtful exploration of alternatives is pursued. These decisions are supported by documentation that reflects the child's needs well and informs matching decision-making, such as 'My place, My home'.
32. Investment in the Foster with Us hub has increased foster carer approvals. This growth has expanded the service's capacity to recruit, assess and provide ongoing support to foster carers. The well-established in-house Foster Care Association is successfully harnessing carers' skills and experience, ensuring they have a strong and influential voice in shaping and improving the service. Foster carers have strong, trusting relationships with their supervising social workers. A comprehensive training programme helps foster carers meet children's individual needs. Foster carers feel valued by the local authority, which supports their retention.
33. Children progress through the adoption process in a timely manner to secure permanence. However, for a small number of children, delays in recruiting

adopters have delayed their move to permanence, even though they are eventually adopted. The local authority has a careful matching process and continues to focus on identifying the right adopters to meet the child's needs. For those children who have progressed through the adoption process, their transitions were well planned, and family time was carefully considered. Once children are settled in their homes, adoption orders are applied for without delay to secure legal permanence. Life-story work, including VMB, ensures that children have a record of early memories. Requests for adoption support are triaged promptly, and assessments are carried out within a reasonable time frame, enabling adoption support to be delivered through a range of therapeutic approaches and support packages.

34. Children in care receive good support to maintain their health and wellbeing, with up-to-date health assessments. Needs are considered in care plans, reviews and supervision, with managers maintaining oversight of children's individual health needs. Dentist reviews and optician records are recorded in children's case records, and most children have up-to-date health assessments. However, this appropriately remains an area of continued focus for the authority.
35. Children are supported in their learning through regular personal education plan (PEP) meetings that capture children's voices and ensure that their support needs are met, helping them to thrive in education. Robust systems, particularly high-quality PEP processes and the effective use of pupil premium plus, provide schools with both support and challenge, improving the quality of planning and provision. Improved attainment and reduced exclusions are a testament to the virtual school's effective advocacy and intervention.
36. Children are supported to engage in a range of activities, interests and hobbies. Many children have had the opportunity to go on holiday with their carers, to celebrate their achievements and to take part in school and community activities.
37. The voice of children and care leavers is well represented in Blackpool. Children and young people told us they felt supported in being heard at the corporate parenting board on issues that matter to them. They are benefiting from the empowerment, support and social interactions provided by being part of the Justuz (children in care), which provides meaningful opportunities to shape services. These children clearly articulated the importance of stability and security in their homes and with their carers, as well as in their relationships with their social worker and IROs. Children know their rights, how to make a complaint and be heard. If they feel they need it, children are supported by independent advocacy to further strengthen their voice. The authority also employs a team of care-experienced youth advisers to represent the voices of young people in strategic and operational boards, including the House of Lords and the Department for Education (DfE).

The experiences and progress of care leavers: outstanding

38. Leaders and practitioners demonstrate strong shared values and a clear commitment to ensuring that care leavers enter adulthood with the support they need, with a genuine sense of possibility. This is evidenced by the council's investment in care leavers up to age 25 and beyond. A positive culture of care, thoughtfully designed services, and a shared commitment to improving care leavers' outcomes are evident.
39. Care leavers benefit from strong, enduring relationships with PAs who know them well. This helps care leavers feel understood, supported and empowered, and provides clear routes for them to seek help or raise concerns.
40. PAs are allocated early. They work closely with the child and their social worker to build relationships and support effective preparation for independence, providing continuity through to adulthood and preventing the abrupt loss of key relationships.
41. There is a clear focus on developing independent living skills, with structured support that continues for as long as needed. A key strength is the strong alignment between Care Act assessments and plans for the disabled care leaver and the pathway plan, ensuring coherent, joined-up planning. Transition planning to adult services is a particular strength, with adult social workers allocated in good time so that they can work alongside social workers and PAs. This enables young people to experience smooth, well-prepared transitions, with increasing independence and, if needed, sustained support into adulthood.
42. Pathway planning is consistently strong, particularly for those under 18. Plans are largely co-produced, up to date, and reflective of the young person's voice. They identify the relevant areas of support, including access to key documentation, and plans outline available ongoing support to meet identified needs, clearly linking this to the local offer and young people's aspirations. PAs demonstrate persistence in engaging care leavers in their plans, and in ensuring access to services, entitlements and key documentation. However, despite the detail, some plans lack specific, measurable outcomes, and this is not identified in case supervision.
43. PAs ensure that young people can access an appropriate range of universal and specialist health services. Health passports and access to the NHS Patch App help young people navigate systems and attend structured appointments, promoting independence. Evidence of timely escalation and access to specialist provision, such as Dialectical Behaviour Therapy, attention deficit hyperactivity disorder, and Right to Choose referrals, demonstrates PAs' persistence and advocacy, actively helping to reduce treatment delays for young people. PAs support care leavers' continued family links, which contribute positively to their emotional stability and identity.

44. There is clear evidence of adapted, purposeful direct work tailored to young people's learning needs, which supports effective engagement. Care leavers benefit from highly responsive, protective practice, with PAs demonstrating strong risk awareness and a clear focus on safety and stability. PAs identify and respond to complex risks effectively, including domestic abuse and mental health issues, through timely, trauma-informed interventions. A key strength is the use of personalised safety planning, which enables care leavers to manage risk and access appropriate support. PAs show tenacity and strong advocacy, working effectively across agencies, including MARAC (Multi-Agency Risk Assessment Conference) and adult safeguarding, and appropriately challenging partner responses. As a result, care leavers are supported to live independently and to manage risks safely.
45. Care leavers have access to the local offer through the Core app, supported by accessible formats to ensure understanding. The offer includes advocacy across housing, health and policing, alongside practical support to secure and sustain accommodation. A clear strength is that the provision is equitable for those living outside of the area, ensuring no disadvantage. The Core, a dedicated space for care leavers to meet and access support, provides a base for young people and demonstrates a strong commitment to belonging and community, with care leavers reporting that they value this support.
46. Care leavers who are parents receive sensitive, relationship-based support that addresses their individual needs and their parenting role effectively. PAs provide timely, tailored interventions, working closely with partner agencies to deliver coordinated, consistent support that strengthens parenting capacity and improves outcomes for children.
47. Care leavers in custody receive strong, consistent, relationship-based support, characterised by warmth and trust. PAs maintain effective links with probation and custodial services. PAs actively sustain contact, including family involvement, to reduce isolation and promote emotional wellbeing. Care leavers benefit from improved engagement, stronger relationships and safer outcomes, with multi-agency resettlement planning in place to support transitions on release.
48. PAs demonstrate tenacity and persistence in securing appropriate housing for care leavers, with clear consideration of readiness for independence. Strong partnership working across housing, charities and third-sector agencies strengthens housing provision. Care leavers are supported to access suitable, stable accommodation, including supported accommodation with responsive, proportionate support and ongoing oversight to ensure the accommodation continues to meet needs. On rare occasions when crisis arrangements are required, hostels or hotels are used. These are time limited and risk managed, alongside active multi-agency work to secure more suitable options. Care leavers receive practical, emotional and financial support, promoting stability.

49. Care leavers in 'staying close' arrangements are well supported in maintaining important family relationships, including those with their brothers and sisters. Transitions from staying put are well planned and appropriately paced, ensuring that young people move on when they are ready and with the right support. Care leavers report feeling safe, settled and supported throughout the process.
50. There is clear evidence of positive and improving outcomes for care leavers in employment, education and training (EET). Participation rates are rising, supported by rigorous tracking, early intervention and targeted support from PAs and multi-agency partners. The support for care leavers to remain in EET is driven by purposeful initiatives and targeted support to pursue aspirational career pathways. The number of care leavers going to university is increasing. Support is personalised and ambitious, including for young people with disabilities, care leavers in custody and those with additional needs. This is strongly aligned with pathway planning and adult services, enabling care leavers to pursue their individual aspirations and fully participate in life. This leads to improved confidence, independence and life chances for care leavers.
51. Support for care leavers aged 21+ is a strong, flexible and relationship-based approach to 'stepping back' support for care leavers, enabling them to seek help when needed. Combined with the 'Always Here' offer, it enables PAs to maintain enduring engagement beyond statutory expectations. Planning is focused and responsive, with proactive contact and effective re-engagement where required. PAs demonstrate strong advocacy and knowledge of entitlements, securing access to housing, EET and wider opportunities for older care leavers. Long-term involvement provides continuity through key transitions, strengthening trust, stability and resilience. Care leavers aged 21+ are supported to sustain independence and make positive progress into adulthood, with some experiencing transformative life changes.

The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families: outstanding

52. Strong political and cross-directorate commitment, together with partner engagement, supports multi-agency practices rooted in supporting children and families across Blackpool. This is evidenced by Blackpool's business ventures, community engagement, and work with education leaders. Co-production with children and families, strengthened health and protection services, and outstanding relationship-based support to children in care and care leavers are a testament to the council's commitment to improving the life chances of all its children in Blackpool.
53. The working relationship between the director of children's services (DCS) and the CEO is highly effective, collaborative and cohesive, making a tangible difference to children and families. Together, they have raised the bar for children and families, exemplifying best practices and ensuring an environment where social work can flourish. They have built a committed and capable senior team and wider workforce that combines local knowledge with external expertise.

54. Governance and oversight arrangements are robust, with regular quality assurance meetings and data-driven performance management. Oversight of quality, caseloads and key performance areas, including attendance and elective home education (EHE), extends across the leadership team, including the DCS and the CEO.
55. There is clear political and corporate leadership commitment to children's services, supported by scrutiny, cabinet and corporate parenting arrangements. Financial investment in children's services is appropriately focused on the key areas of workforce, early help and sufficiency, as well as on increasing foster care capacity.
56. Partnership working arrangements have improved significantly and are now a real strength in Blackpool. The deliberate effort to increase accountability across partners, bringing the multi-agency safeguarding arrangements under local control, has enabled leaders to focus on priorities important to Blackpool. There is evidence of greater partner accountability, with joint scrutiny of issues such as EHE and child exploitation.
57. Leaders continue to strengthen relationships with the integrated care board and the police, and there is evidence of improvement, with work ongoing to achieve greater alignment in delivering a joint children's agenda. The Request for Support hub is a partnership strength and a testament to the success of this work, with co-located teams and stable management. The voluntary sector also plays an important role, particularly in adolescent and youth provision.
58. The Corporate Parenting Board has renewed its focus and, over the past 18 months, has placed strong emphasis on the voices of children and young people. Meetings have been redesigned to ensure active participation, with young people chairing discussions and shaping priorities on key themes that matter to them. Feedback indicates that young people feel heard and valued.
59. Leaders know their services well, as reflected in the self-evaluation, which is appropriately detailed, informed by feedback from children, families and carers, and grounded in quality assurance findings. The evaluation realistically identifies challenges and areas for improvement. It is refreshingly honest, seeks out learning opportunities and is highly aspirational for children and families, aiming to make a positive and sustainable difference.
60. Leaders' understanding of the data aligns with Ofsted inspection findings. The revised quality assurance, learning and improvement framework demonstrates that leaders and managers understand their practice and the areas where progress is required. Effective plans are in place to address these areas.
61. Leaders have made remarkable progress in addressing the areas to improve identified at previous inspections. They have welcomed external scrutiny, and

used this feedback not only to address areas for improvement but also to exceed the required standards and to sharpen practices and processes beyond them. While some areas remain a focus for continued improvement, inspectors were reassured by the actions taken thus far and by the positive impact of the initial stages of some of the more recent achievements.

62. Help and protection services continue to operate effectively, despite the ongoing challenges of high levels of deprivation and demand for services. Ongoing pressures for children and young people due to low attendance, and the support needed for the high numbers of children who are EHE or not in education, employment, or training, are now being successfully addressed at both strategic and operational levels. High numbers of children in care and sufficiency pressures persist, particularly in fostering. The highly credible sufficiency strategy is beginning to have a tangible impact on securing placements, achieving timely permanence and increasing stability for children.
63. The Blackpool Families Rock culture and model of practice principles (head – how we think, heart – how we behave, and hands – how we work) are evident throughout the work of practitioners and sit alongside the social work practice model. Both are embedded across the partnership. Leaders in children’s social care services have successfully inspired and exemplified a genuine, caring culture that is open to learning, developing and strengthening practices for children and families. They have willingly engaged with external challenges, learned from peer reviews and worked positively with the DfE to continually shape and develop practices.
64. Workforce stability has improved significantly, including across the senior leadership team and the management tiers of children’s services. Blackpool children’s services now have an extremely committed, motivated and engaged workforce. Practitioners know their children well and remain consistent sources of support, with many social workers, PAs and IROs working with their children for many years. The vast majority of children and young people, including disabled children, benefit from high-quality, relationship-based practice, including skilled direct work.
65. Although challenges remain, particularly high caseloads and a relatively inexperienced workforce, leaders have concrete plans to address these issues. The workforce is confident in the leadership of the director of children’s services and her senior team through to team managers. They report being very well supported, which is evidence of the success of the driving force behind the transformational culture change that ensures the effective delivery of services to children and families in Blackpool.

The Office for Standards in Education, Children's Services and Skills (Ofsted) regulates and inspects to achieve excellence in the care of children and young people, and in education and skills for learners of all ages. It regulates and inspects childcare and children's social care, and inspects the Children and Family Court Advisory and Support Service (Cafcass), schools, colleges, initial teacher training, further education and skills, adult and community learning, and education and training in prisons and other secure establishments. It assesses council children's services, and inspects services for looked-after children, safeguarding and child protection.

If you would like a copy of this document in a different format, such as large print or Braille, please telephone 0300 123 1231, or email enquiries@ofsted.gov.uk.

You may reuse this information (not including logos) free of charge in any format or medium, under the terms of the Open Government Licence. To view this licence, visit www.nationalarchives.gov.uk/doc/open-government-licence, write to the Information Policy Team, The National Archives, Kew, London TW9 4DU, or email: psi@nationalarchives.gsi.gov.uk.

This report is available at <https://reports.ofsted.gov.uk/>.

Interested in our work? You can subscribe to our monthly newsletter for more information and updates: <http://eepurl.com/iTrDn>.

Piccadilly Gate
Store Street
Manchester
M1 2WD

T: 0300 123 1231
Textphone: 0161 618 8524
E: enquiries@ofsted.gov.uk
W: www.gov.uk/ofsted

© Crown copyright 2026